the simple guide to KICKASS KOMBUCHA

RECIPES, FLAVORS, TIPS, & MORE!

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LET'S GET BREWING!

Kombucha brewing goes a bit like this:

1. Make SCOBY (1-4 weeks) – make the "mother" *(page 6)*
2. First fermentation (6-10 days) – make the actual kombucha *(page 9)*
3. Second fermentation (3-10 days) – carbonate the kombucha *(page 12)*

Before we start, there are some general points that are consistent throughout the process of brewing kombucha:

- **No metal or plastic containers.** Metal can react with the acidic kombucha and hurt your SCOBY, while plastic can house nasty bacteria that you don't want sneaking in.
- **Clean is key.** A recurring theme in kombucha brewing is that EVERYTHING must be CLEAN! We're creating the perfect environment for good bacterial growth, but if a bad bacteria slips in, it could ruin your batch (and make you pretty sick).
- **Temperature plays a role.** Fermentation goes quicker in warmer temperatures and slower in colder.
- **No mold zone.** If you see any mold growing on your SCOBY or in the tea (it will generally be green, white, or black), you'll need to toss your whole batch.

HI, I'M SARAH!

A kombucha obsessive helping hundreds of home brewers make kickass kombucha! Read more **about Live Eat Learn** or **about my kombucha journey**

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Ready to level up?

...or **have questions** about brewing?

...or not sure **where to get the starter**?

...or want a **deeper dive** into kombucha?

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for our

49 page comprehensive guide
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Join the community!

Looking for advice, have questions,

or just want to talk brewing?

Join our FREE Facebook group!

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Kombucha Making Supplies

1st Fermentation
You'll just need three things: a big jar, something to cover the jar, and something to strain the kombucha afterwards!

- ❏ Large jar
- ❏ Cheesecloth or towel
- ❏ Mesh strainer

2nd Fermentation
Aim for fermentation-grade flip top bottles, which will trap the carbon dioxide and make fizzier kombucha!

- ❏ Fliptop fermentation bottles
- ❏ Labels
- ❏ Blender

Specialty Products
Ready to step it up a notch? These tools are affordable yet useful in maintaining a healthy fermentation station!

- ❏ pH test strips
- ❏ Alcohol indicator
- ❏ Jar warmer

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STEP 1 – MAKE SCOBY

The SCOBY (Symbiotic Culture Of Bacteria and Yeast) is the mother of the kombucha, providing bacteria and yeast that ferment the tea and protecting it from outside contaminants. Once you have your SCOBY, you can use it for all future batches. It will continue to grow with every batch!

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1. How to make a kombucha SCOBY

SCOBY Ingredients:

- 7 cups (1.6 L) water
- ½ cup (100 g) white sugar
- 4 bags black tea
- 1 cup (235 mL) unpasteurized, unflavored store-bought kombucha

Equipment:

- 1 gallon glass or ceramic jar
- Tightly woven cloth
- Rubberbands

Things to note when making your SCOBY:

- **No decaf:** The SCOBY doesn't like decaf tea and will not grow as well if fed it.
- **Only black tea:** The SCOBY doesn't grow well with green or fruity teas. Once your SCOBY is larger you can use green tea, but for now stick with black.
- **No honey:** Honey can contain botulism bacteria that, when grown exponentially as bacteria and yeast tend to do in kombucha, can be dangerous. You can use honey in the second fermentation, once there are a higher number of good bacteria to fight off the bad, but for now, stick to sugar.

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1. How to make a kombucha SCOBY

SCOBY Instructions:

1. **Make Sweet Tea**: Bring water to a boil. Remove from heat and dissolve sugar into it. Add the tea bags and allow them to steep for at least 20 minutes (or until tea has cooled).
2. **Cool to Room Temp**: Allow hot tea to cool to room temperature. Quicken this process by boiling just 2 cups of water, dissolving the sugar, and steeping the tea for 20 minutes. Then add remaining 5 cups of cold water, which will bring the mixture to room temperature faster. Test that the tea is room temperature by drawing out some tea with a paper straw, using your finger to keep the kombucha in the straw.
3. **Add Starter**: Pour the sweetened tea into your jar, then pour store-bought kombucha in, making sure to include any gunkies that may be at the bottom of the kombucha bottle. These are great for kickstarting the fermentation!
4. **Cover**: Cover with a few layers of the tightly woven cloth to keep out bugs and debris, securing with a rubber band.
5. **Ferment**: Set somewhere dark, still, and room temperature (70-75 degrees F, 21-24 C) for 1 to 4 weeks, until a ¼ inch (½ cm) SCOBY has formed.
6. **Go to 1st Fermentation**: You now have a SCOBY! The SCOBY should live and grow for years if treated with love. Allow the SCOBY to remain in this liquid until you are ready to use the SCOBY for the next step, the 1st fermentation.

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STEP 2 – 1ST FERMENTATION

So you've got a SCOBY and you're ready to get this komboo-choo train rollin'. The first fermentation is where you actually *make* the kombucha that you'll be drinking!

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2. First Fermentation

Ingredients:

- 14 cups (3.3 L) water
- 1 cup (200 g) white sugar
- 8 bags black tea
- 2 cups (480 mL) unpasteurized, unflavored store-bought kombucha
- 1 SCOBY

Equipment:

- 1 gallon glass or ceramic jar
- Tightly woven cloth
- Rubberbands

Things to note about the first fermentation:

- **Other teas** can be used in this step! Feel free to experiment with green, white, oolong, or combinations of them. Fruit teas should be mixed with a few black tea bags to ensure the SCOBY gets what she needs to thrive.
- **Big SCOBY?** Once the SCOBY gets to be about an inch thick, peel off a few layers to create a second SCOBY (use it to create another batch or gift it to a friend!)

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2. First Fermentation

Instructions:

1. **Make Sweet Tea**: Bring water to a boil. Remove from heat and dissolve sugar into it. Add the tea bags and allow them to steep for at least 20 minutes (or until tea has cooled).
2. **Cool to Room Temp**: Allow hot tea to cool to room temperature. Quicken this process by boiling just 4 cups of water, dissolving the sugar, and steeping the tea for 20 minutes. Then add remaining 10 cups of cold water, which will bring the mixture to room temperature faster. Test that the tea is room temperature by drawing out some tea with a paper straw, using your finger to keep the kombucha in the straw. (*Don't be impatient here – hot water will kill your SCOBY).*
3. **Empty the Jar**: With very clean hands, transfer SCOBY to an equally clean plate. If this is your first round of kombucha, reserve 2 cups of the liquid the SCOBY was growing in (that can be your starter kombucha), discarding the rest of the liquid (it is very acidic and not nice for drinking).
4. **Add Starter**: Pour the sweetened tea into your jar, then pour in unflavored starter kombucha. With clean hands, place SCOBY into jar.
5. **Cover**: Cover with a few layers of the tightly woven cloth and secure with a rubber band.
6. **Ferment**: Set the jar somewhere dark, still, and room temperature (70-75 degrees F, 21-24 C) for 6 to 10 days. Begin tasting at about 6 days by gently drawing out some of the tea with a paper straw (using your finger to hold the tea in the straw – don't use your mouth). It should be mildly sweet and slightly vinegary. The warmer the air temperature, the faster the kombucha will ferment. The longer the tea ferments, the more sugar molecules will be eaten up, the less sweet it will be.
7. **Go to 2nd Fermentation**: Reserve 2 cups from this batch to use as starter kombucha for your next batch (just leave it in the jar with SCOBY). The rest can move into the second and final fermentation.

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STEP 3 – 2ND FERMENTATION

The final and most fun step in the homemade kombucha making process!
The second fermentation is where the real magic happens,
flavoring and carbonating your kombucha into fizzy, effervescent bliss.

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2. Second Fermentation

Ingredients:

- Homemade kombucha from the first fermentation
- Sweetener (fruit, honey, or sugar). We usually work with a ratio of 1 cup kombucha to:
  - 1 to 2 Tbsp mashed fruit or fruit juice
  - 1 to 2 tsp honey or sugar

Equipment:

- Flip top fermentation bottles (whichever size you prefer, as long as together they hold 14 cups)

Things to note about the second fermentation:

- **Blast Zone:** Your jars can explode if the pressure becomes too high! For your first few batches while you're still getting the hang of how kombucha reacts to your environment, bottle a portion of it in a plastic bottle (like a clean disposable water bottle). This will act as a gauge for the others; when the plastic bottle is rock solid, the rest are probably done. "Burp" them by opening each to release some pressure, then place them in the refrigerator to slow fermentation.
- **Faster Fermentation:** Be aware that the kombucha will ferment more quickly when it is warmer and when there is more sugar/fruit. It will ferment more slowly in the opposite conditions!

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2. Second Fermentation

Instructions:

1. **Bottle**: Funnel kombucha into bottles, leaving about 2 to 3 empty inches at the top.
2. **Sweeten**: Add your chosen sweetener and seal tightly.
3. **Ferment**: Let ferment somewhere dark and room temperature for 3 to 10 days.
4. **Serve**: If desired, strain out fruit before serving. Place in fridge to slow the carbonation process and to chill before serving.

Flavoring Ideas (per ½ gallon kombucha):

- **Lemon Ginger**: ¼ cup fresh lemon juice, 1 thumb ginger, 2 tsp honey
- **Peach Pie**: 1 peach, 2 Tbsp maple syrup, ½ tsp vanilla extract
- **Strawberry**: ½ cup halved strawberries (optionally add ¼ cup fresh basil!)
- **Mojito**: 2 limes (zest + juice), 2 Tbsp brown sugar, 2 sprigs mint
- **Pumpkin Spice**: ½ cup pumpkin puree, 2 tsp pumpkin spice, 1 tsp fresh ginger, ½ tsp vanilla extract, 2 cinnamon sticks
- **Pineapple Basil**: ½ cup chopped pineapple, ¼ cup fresh basil

See more of our favorite flavors here!

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Follow along on my new site **BrewBuch.com**,
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